An open observatory of mortality data would show the next fall in life expectancy as it happens

A proposal for two years of funding, with the evidence of 74 years of data

Vellum example deck · illustrative proposal · A. Kaminas · 12 October 2026

World life expectancy fell 1.7 years in 2020 and 2021

−1.7 years

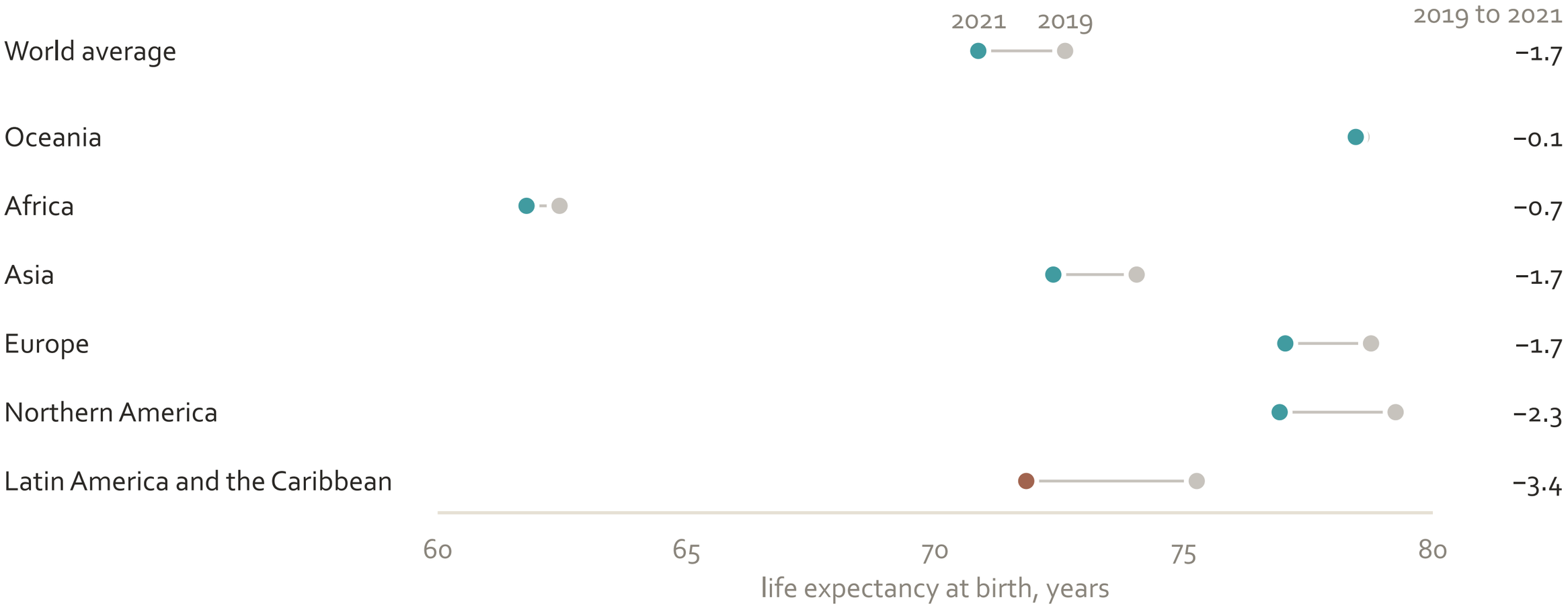
world life expectancy at birth, 2019 to 2021

the deepest fall since 1959–60, which cost 3.8 years

It took the world back to about its 2012 level: nine years of gains, lost in two.

Period life expectancy at birth, world, 2019 and 2021 · UN World Population Prospects (2024)

The world average hides falls of 0.1 to 3.4 years across regions



Period life expectancy at birth in the six UN regions, 2019 and 2021 · UN World Population Prospects (2024)

Five steps would turn death registers into open monthly estimates

1

Collect

weekly death counts from national registers

→

2

Harmonise

ages, dates and definitions across countries

→

3

Estimate

monthly life expectancy with its uncertainty

→

4

Publish

open data and code under CC BY 4.0

→

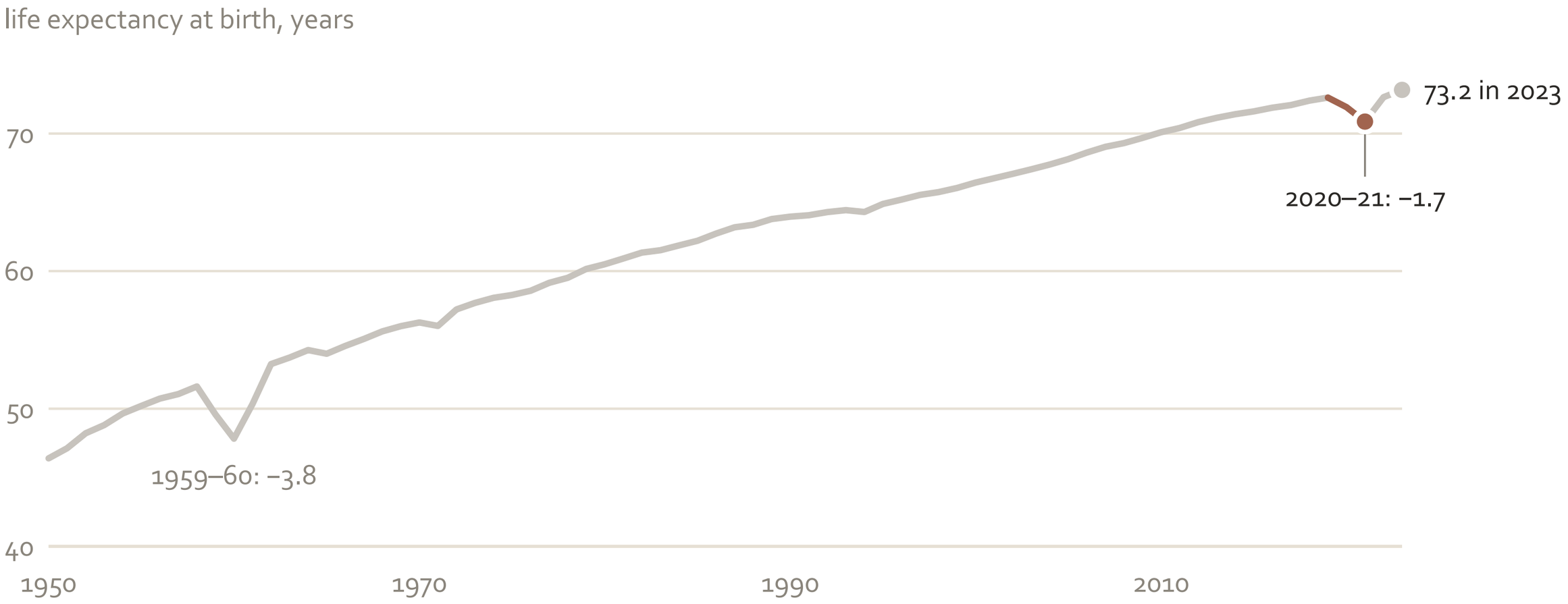
5

Flag

any fall below a country's 2019 level

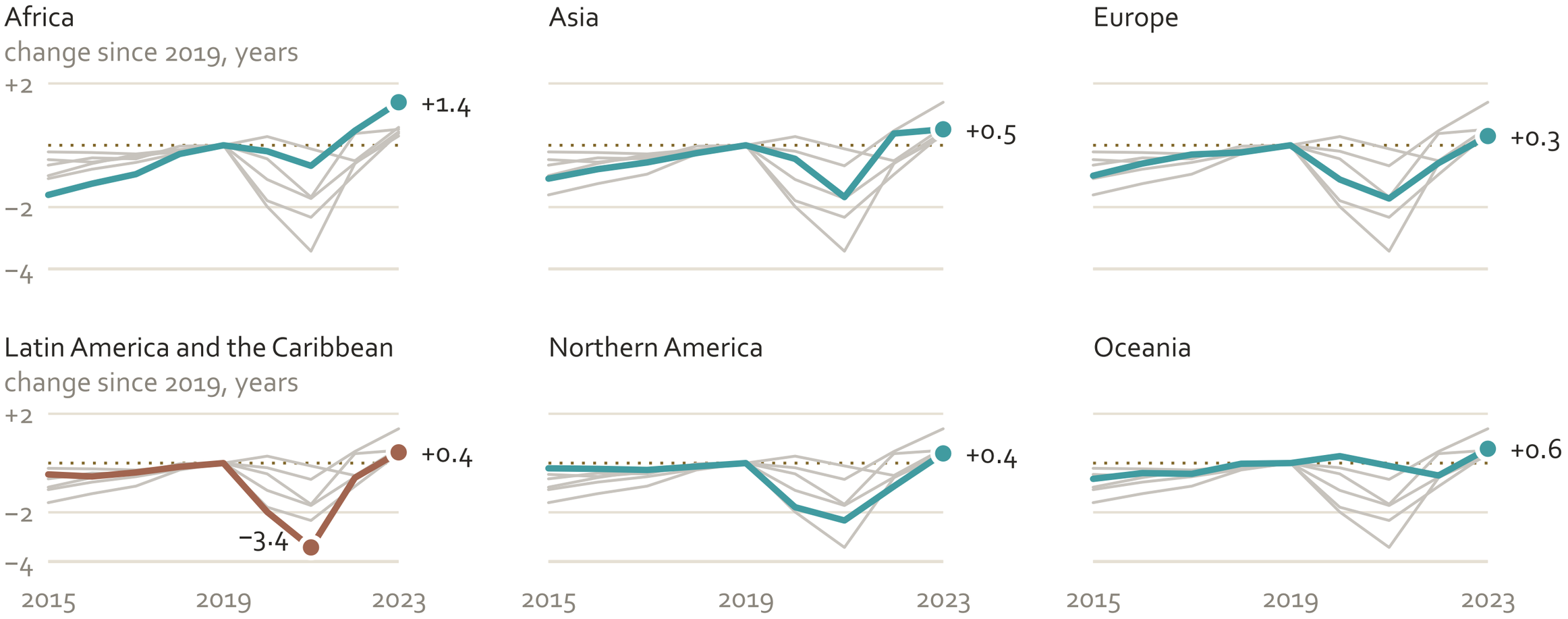
Illustrative: the pipeline is invented for this example deck; the steps are those of a mortality nowcast

In 2020–21 world life expectancy had its deepest fall since 1960



Period life expectancy at birth, world, 1950–2023 · UN World Population Prospects (2024)

Every region was back above its 2019 level by 2023



Change from each UN region's 2019 level (dotted) in life expectancy at birth · UN World Population Prospects (2024)

Every release would cover 236 countries and territories since 1950

236

countries and territories

17,464 country-years in all

74

years of annual estimates

1950 to 2023, one value a year

12

open releases a year, one a month

illustrative target

236 and 74: counted in the UN World Population Prospects (2024) series · 12: illustrative

The first open release would come six months after funding



Illustrative: milestones invented for this example deck; months counted from the start of funding

Two years of funding would build and open the observatory

€1.2 million

over 24 months, the whole ask

staff €0.84 million · infrastructure €0.24 million · data partnerships €0.12 million

Illustrative: the budget is invented for this example deck

Every number in this deck is computed from one open data file

A. Kaminas

akaminas.github.io/vellum

Data: UN World Population Prospects (2024), Human Mortality Database (2024), Zijdeman and Ribeira da Silva (2015), Riley (2005); processed by Our World in Data, downloaded 2026-10-12; CC BY 4.0. Every number on the evidence slides is computed by the script from that file.

Drawn by examples/python/pitch/make_pitch.py · git 99753b9-dirty · 12 October 2026 · Vellum example deck · illustrative proposal